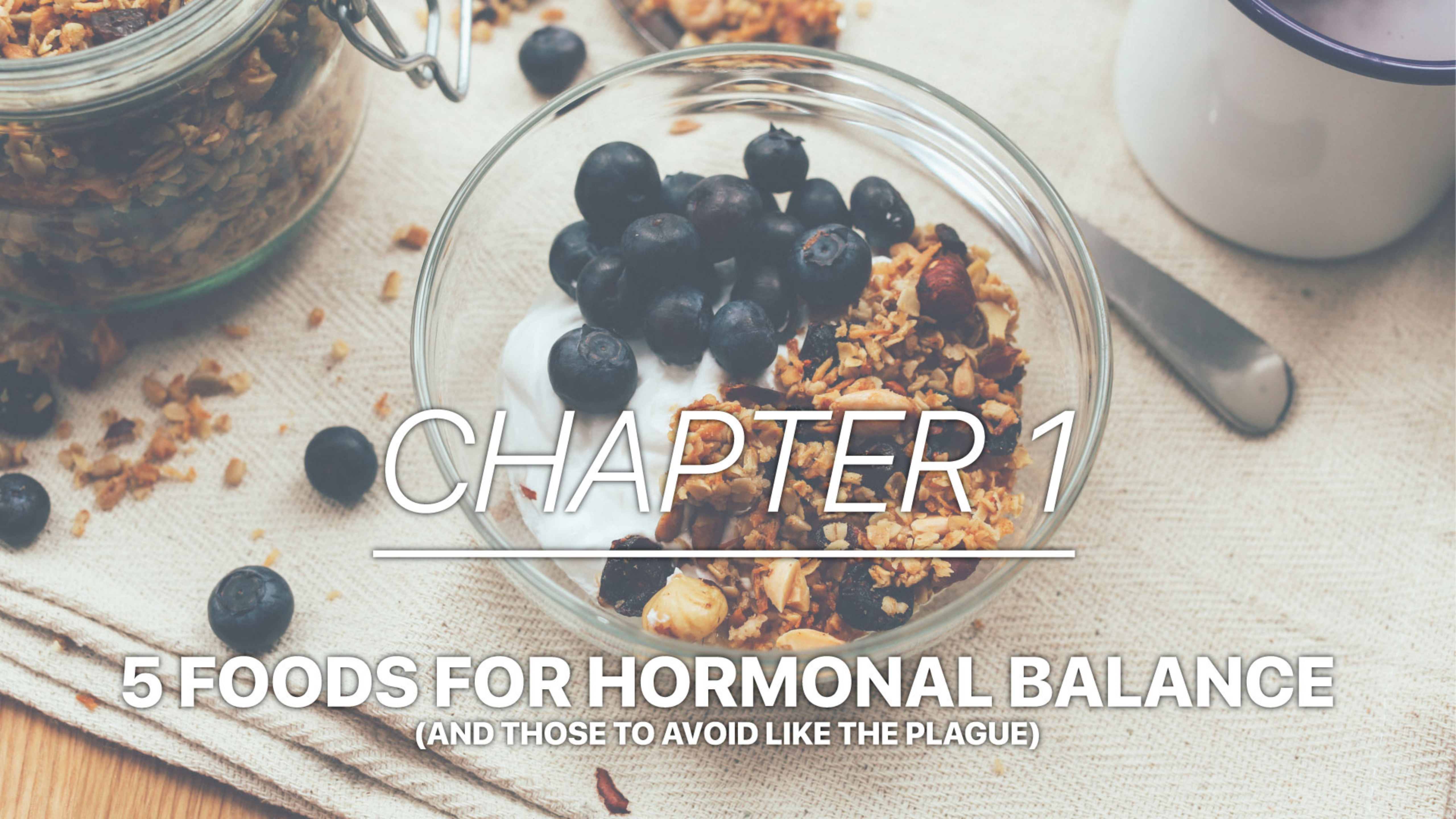


HOW TO FEEL AMAZING IN MENOPAUSE

– Dr. Jennifer Nevels, NMD



A top-down view of a glass bowl filled with white yogurt, topped with a generous amount of granola and several fresh blueberries. The bowl sits on a light-colored, textured fabric surface. In the background, a glass jar with a metal clasp is filled with more granola, and a knife lies on the fabric. The overall scene is bright and clean, suggesting a healthy breakfast.

CHAPTER 1

5 FOODS FOR HORMONAL BALANCE

(AND THOSE TO AVOID LIKE THE PLAGUE)

PREFACE:

Whenever possible, it is best to eat organic foods in order to avoid pesticides and genetically modified foods, both of which will harm us more than help us.



FLAX SEEDS



Flax seeds are a plant-like estrogen. This means they bind to an estrogen receptor like the hormone estrogen but are just 1000x weaker, so they can help with mild symptoms of menopause, including hot flashes. Flax seeds are also high in fiber which is, of course, good for bowel function and also good for cholesterol. When flax seeds are ground, Omega 3s are released and therefore provide the benefit of anti-inflammatory properties as well. Two to three tablespoons of flax seeds added to smoothies, salads or oatmeal can be a great way to incorporate this daily.

BERRIES

...PARTICULARLY BLUEBERRIES

Berries are fantastic for us. Blueberries are particularly good for us because they're high in vitamin C, vitamin A, and other antioxidants like anthocyanins that protect against heart disease, cancer. For those who have varicose veins, blueberries have been shown to strengthen the vessel wall which can decrease further varicosities. About a cup a day of frozen or fresh organic blueberries is best.



BRAZIL NUTS

Brazil nuts have a high amount of selenium. Selenium is a fantastic mineral to help thyroid function. If the thyroid isn't working optimally, which we'll talk more about later, our energy can be significantly impacted. Thyroid dysfunction can change our mood and cause feelings of depression or anxiety as well as induce issues with temperature regulation, meaning you may often feel too cold, and even too hot in some cases. Increased consumption of Brazil nuts can assist with these problems. Brazil nuts also contain potassium, calcium, and magnesium, and have been shown to increase HDL, which is a good cholesterol. So, 2-3 a day have many benefits. In fact, a study was done in Brazil in 2015 on individuals with particularly low T3, which is one of the most important thyroid hormones. By eating Brazil nuts every day, the individuals in the study reversed that issue. Consider adding Brazil nuts to your routine to experience these benefits for yourself.

APPLE CIDER VINEGAR

Apple cider vinegar is a great health aid to add to your daily routine. It increases the acid in the stomach, which allows for better digestion. A lot of digestive issues are related to low acid in the stomach. Having more acid allows us to absorb vitamins and minerals from our foods more optimally. Apple cider vinegar allows the body to become more alkaline and alkalinity is important as it is anti-cancer and helps with bone density. You can increase the apple cider vinegar in your diet by regularly adding 1-2 TBSP of apple cider vinegar in water (you can add a little Stevia to help with the taste). You can do this daily or before every meal, especially if you have digestive issues.



VEGETABLES

The more colorful the vegetable, the more beneficial, preferably organic greens. Greens are particularly beneficial because they contain calcium and, like apple cider vinegar, can help with alkalinity and optimizing bone density (both of which can be issues in the menopausal years.) For best results, you should consume at least 5 cups of vegetables a day whether it be in salads, stir-fries, or other preferred dishes. Any way you can find to add vegetables to your diet would be a great benefit.



"NO!" FOODS

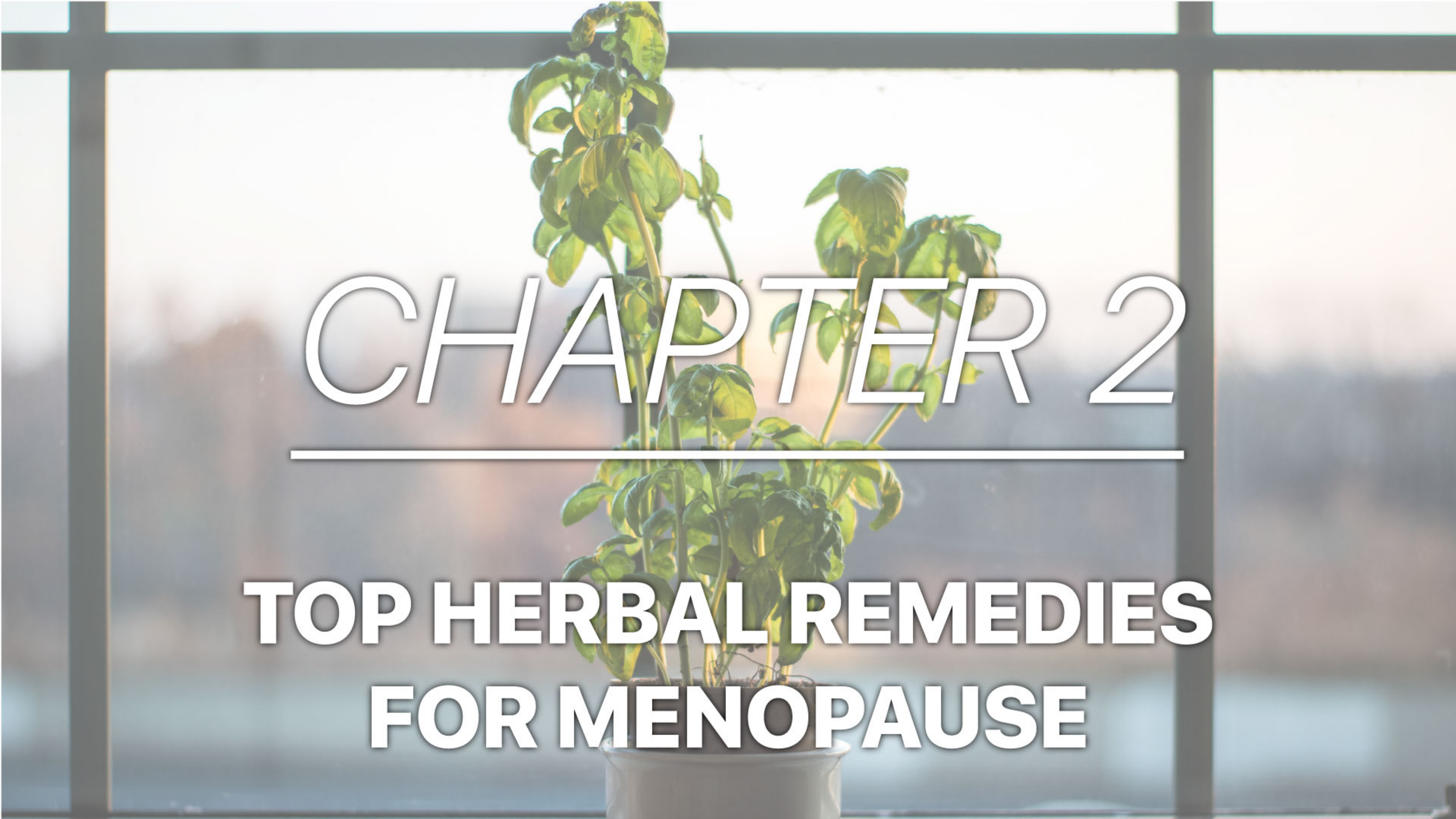
SUGARS

Sugar is an inflammatory and can be a trigger for hot flashes. Processed sugar should especially be avoided. So, keep this in mind and try to really minimize sugar intake, particularly if you are experiencing either inflammation or hot flashes.

SPICY FOODS

It is recommended to avoid both spicy foods and caffeine during the menopausal years as they are common triggers for hot flashes. If someone has mild hot flashes, avoiding these foods may help decrease the hot flashes immensely. If someone has very severe hot flashes, they may see a decrease in symptoms by eliminating these foods. This diet change may not eliminate hot flashes entirely if there is a major imbalance but there should still be an improvement in symptoms.



A potted basil plant with green leaves is positioned in front of a window. The window looks out onto a blurred landscape featuring a body of water and distant mountains under a soft, hazy sky. The text 'CHAPTER 2' is overlaid in a large, white, serif font with a thin black outline. A horizontal white line is placed directly beneath the word 'CHAPTER'.

CHAPTER 2

TOP HERBAL REMEDIES FOR MENOPAUSE

SAGE TEA

Sage can be very helpful for hot flashes. Sage can reduce hot flashes by 50% and studies have shown that those who drink four cups of sage tea a day, have improved memory, especially

in women over 65. Sage can also improve symptoms of depression and anxiety and can also assist in balancing hormones.

Recipe for Sage Tea:

4 cups of water

1 cup of sage

Steps: *Boil water first then take off heat and add the herb. Cover and let steep for 20-30 minutes.*

Drink it throughout the day. You can also drink it as an iced tea after you seep the herb.

MACA

Maca is an herb that benefits the thyroid, the adrenals, and the ovaries. There are many different versions of Maca and they are not all created equal. MacaPause by Femmenessence is recommended as it is made with MacaGo, a certified organic proprietary blend that is unique in comparison to the other Macas because it is more concentrated and the effectiveness is far superior to other Maca you may get. A study was conducted on individuals who were taking Maca daily. After 4 months, study participants had an 84% reduction in their symptoms including a reduction in hot flashes as well as improved libido, sleep, memory, mood and energy. Study participants also demonstrated an increased testosterone level in their blood.

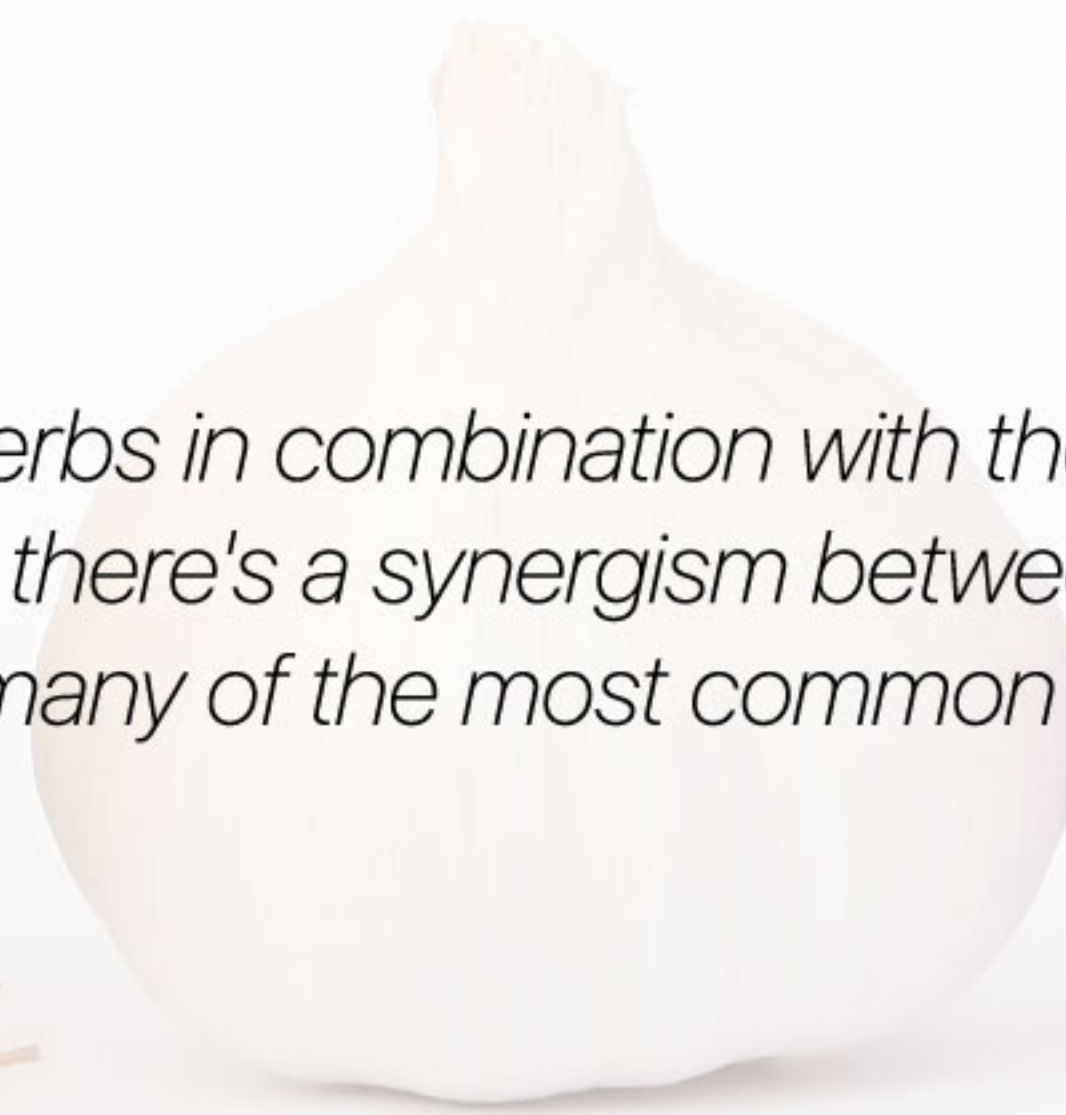
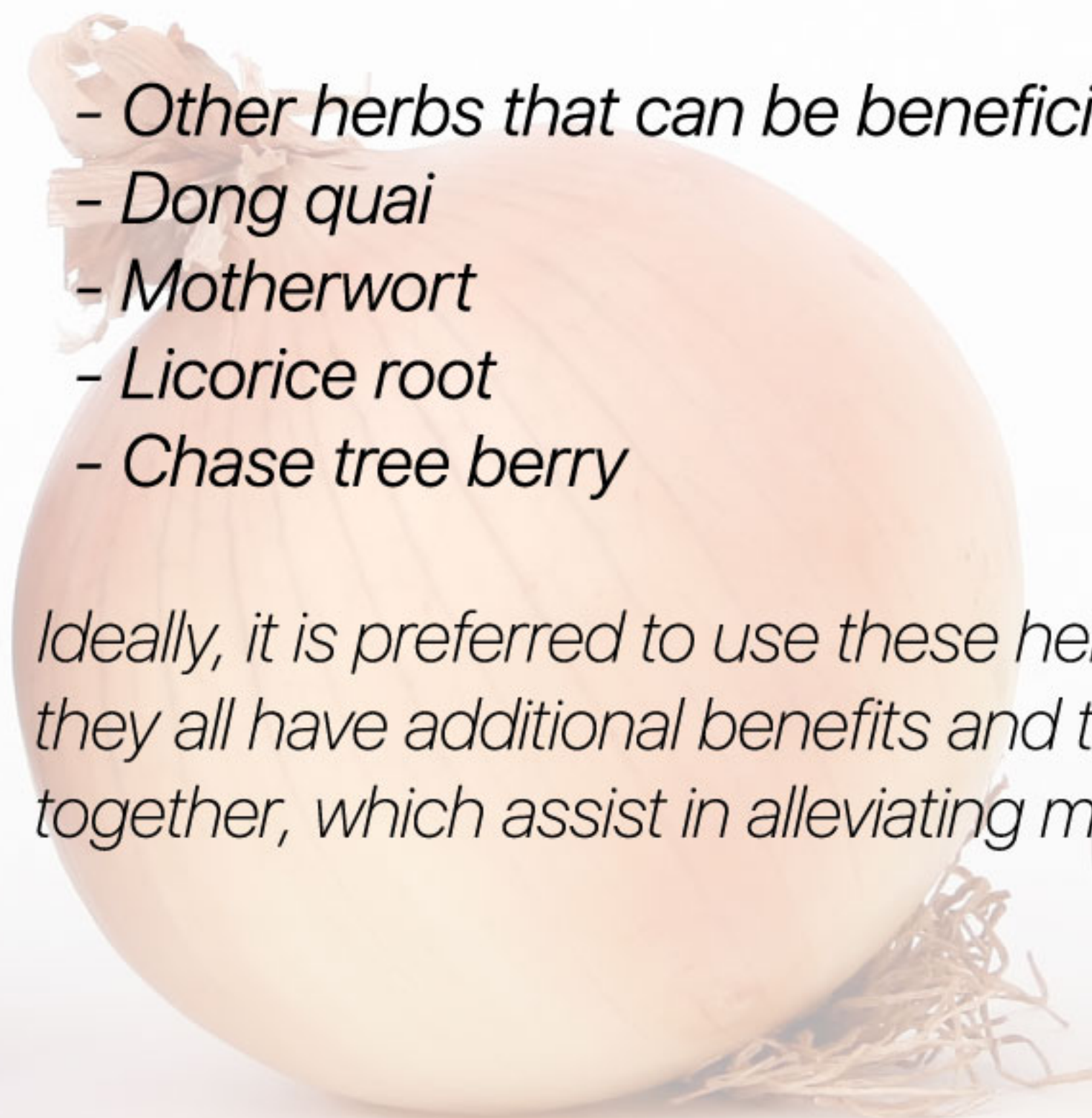
HERBAL COMBINATIONS

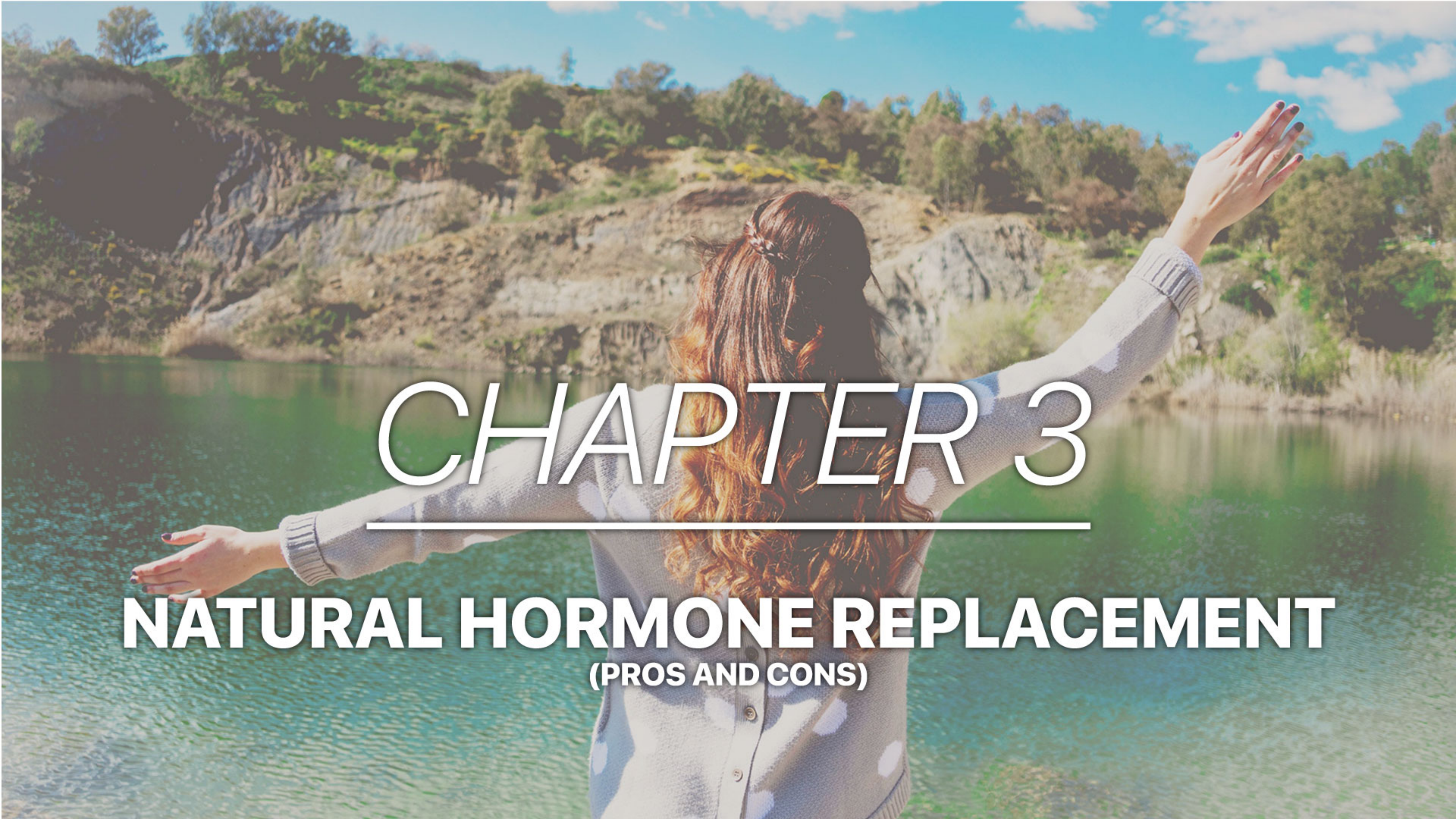
Black Cohosh is probably the most common, well-known herb when it comes to benefits in a menopausal woman. It's most helpful with reducing hot flashes and night sweats. It can also help with relieving anxiety and depression, aid in relieving insomnia, and can sometimes be helpful for those who have inflammatory issues, aches, and pains.

- Other herbs that can be beneficial include:

- Dong quai*
- Motherwort*
- Licorice root*
- Chase tree berry*

Ideally, it is preferred to use these herbs in combination with the Black Cohosh because they all have additional benefits and there's a synergism between them all when taken together, which assist in alleviating many of the most common issues with menopause.





CHAPTER 3

NATURAL HORMONE REPLACEMENT

(PROS AND CONS)

DIFFERENT ESTROGENS

1. *Conventional Estrogens*–Conventional Hormone Replacement Therapy, particularly estrogen, is an estrogen you can get at a mainstream pharmacy such as Walgreens or CVS. One form it comes in is as Premarin cream, made from pregnant horses' urine, that can provide hot flash or other menopausal relief. More commonly, estradiol is prescribed to take orally, in a pill form. There are also lots of patches available, where the estrogen is released through the skin to be absorbed.

2. *Bio-identical Estrogens*– Bio-identical estrogens are made in a process where a hormone is developed to look identical to that of the body's natural hormones, and hence there will be more similar reactions and greater benefits without limiting side effects.

Bio-Identical hormones can come in either a conventional form or compounded form. Conventional sources of hormone therapy come in three different doses which don't allow for a lot of variety. Contrarily, compounding hormones are made at a compounding pharmacy, where physicians can call in any level or amount of hormone to the compounding pharmacist in any route they need to have it administered, which allows for a lot more individualization. A greater distinction between conventional and compounding sources is the use of the different types of estrogens. Estradiol can be in either a conventional or bio-identical form. However, through the use of compounding, the combination of estradiol and estriol becomes a possibility.

To further break it down, Beta and Alpha receptors are the most well-known estrogen receptors we have in the body. Beta receptors are specific to benefits with anti-inflammation, helps protect the brain and its function, and it can reduce breast, colon, and ovarian cancer risk. The estrogen receptor Alphas help with the bone formation, which is extremely important for bone density, and they also help with neuroprotection for the brain. This receptor is more commonly utilized when breasts are beginning to be developed in puberty, so any breast gland development is a factor for the estrogen receptor Alpha, and then cancer is promoted when this Alpha is stimulated. Thus, estradiol binds to both Beta and Alpha receptors while the estriol binds primarily with the Beta receptors, which have reduced the risks of breast, colon and ovarian cancers.

Understanding the benefits of both estradiol and estriol when diving into hormone therapy replacement helps explain the benefit of using a bioidentical compounded version of estradiol and estriol. Estriol being used alone just isn't as effective as estradiol. For optimal benefits with hot flash reduction and improved mood, a bio-identical compound of 20% estradiol and 80% of estriol all the way up to a 50-50 change should be considered.



CHAPTER 4

**3 HEALTH ISSUES THAT MASQUERADE
AS HORMONAL IMBALANCE**
(AND HOW TO KNOW)

DIFFERENT DELIVERY SYSTEMS

- As far as delivery systems, this is another difference between a compounding formula and a traditional, conventional formula. There are creams using Bi-est, meaning 2 estrogens, estradiol and estriol. This cream is probably the most common form of estrogen used. Using a cream is preferable because it's well absorbed when it's applied properly to the thinnest skinned areas of the body like wrists, behind the knees, and tops of feet.
- Lozenges, or troches, are another delivery system. These are basically placed in the mouth next to the mucosal membrane, which is the inner cheek, for absorption into the bloodstream.
- Other ways of delivering hormones include injections (particularly for testosterone) as well as pellets. These subdermal pellets are basically an incision in the hip where hormones are placed for a 3-4 months time span. This delivery system yields mixed results with patients. Of all of the delivery systems mentioned, creams are preferable, but lozenges may be a good option for patients who have not seen any benefits after using creams.

SAFE USE OF HORMONES

- There are some safety precautions to consider in the use of hormone replacement therapy.

1. A family history of breast cancer. If there is an estrogen receptor or a progesterone receptor positive for breast cancer in your mother, hormone therapy would not be advisable. While genetics don't dictate everything, there are many other ways to have relief during menopause without doing hormone therapy. Likewise, if there's a personal history of breast cancer, hormone replacement therapy wouldn't be advised.

2. Oral estrogens. Oral estrogens imply a capsule that is swallowed and refers back to the conventional way of receiving hormone therapy. Estradiol, when swallowed, can trigger clotting factors and can also provoke some of the inflammatory markers, which can be tested for through a blood test called C Reactive Protein, or CRP. When CRP is elevated in the blood, it increases inflammation in the blood vessels, and in turn, can increase the risk for heart attacks and strokes. Because of the connection between oral estrogens and increased CRP, it would be advisable to consider something safer if you are currently using oral estrogens.

Progesterone can be a fantastic hormone to use and sometimes when women are going through menopause, they can handle all of their symptoms with herbs. However, some women still struggle to achieve a good quality of life with herbs alone, which is when it may be necessary to resort to hormonal therapy. Some women do great just using progesterone, especially if the issue is insomnia. Progesterone is typically produced in the woman's body when experiencing normal cycles prior to menopause. Usually, it is promoted in the body for two weeks out of the month. However, when ovulation and regular cycles are no longer occurring, the production of progesterone really declines, and hence, the benefits provided by that progesterone are lost. Progesterone, when broken down by the body, turns into a metabolite that binds to receptors in the brain called Gamma-aminobutyric acid, or GABA, is a brain chemical that helps with anxiety when it's promoted properly and it can help with good quality sleep. When levels of progesterone are low, which naturally happens with menopause, some menopausal issues could be remedied with the use of progesterone via hormone replacement therapy. Progesterone, like estrogens, can be made up in a cream form. It can be also used conventionally, meaning you can get it at traditional pharmacies such as Walgreens or CVS. Progesterone is bio-identical and also comes in a pill for which can be even more sedating than other forms. This option may be especially helpful when dealing with insomnia. Progesterone will often be prescribed if an individual is already using estrogen as the progesterone decreases the risk of cancer in the uterus. If you have had a hysterectomy, and therefore no longer have a uterus, not all of these recommendations may apply to you.

Testosterone can also be used as an option in hormone treatment for someone who has low libido, fatigue, and low testosterone levels in the blood. Like other hormone replacement treatments, testosterone is available in various forms. In situations where multiple hormones may be needed, everything can be added into one cream.



3 Health Problems that Masquerade as Hormonal Imbalance

While there are many health issues that can masquerade as hormonal imbalances, there are three in particular that are pertinent to the discussion surrounding menopause: adrenal and thyroid dysfunction, digestive issues, and food intolerances or allergies. There are many patients who do fantastic with just herbal remedies, but there are also those who don't improve even with high doses of hormone replacement therapy, which means something is missing and could very well be attributed to one or more of these three health problems. Depending on presenting symptoms, these health concerns may be something to investigate regardless of the state of hormonal balance.

ADRENAL/THYROID IMBALANCE

When adrenal or thyroid dysfunctions are present, there can be many symptoms that result. A common contributing theme to symptoms is stress, especially when it comes to these two glands. The adrenals are small glands that sit on top of the kidneys and produce a multitude of hormones:

- Adrenaline – This includes norepinephrine and epinephrine, both of which are pumping through the veins when under stress or experiencing anxiety.*
- Cortisol– Cortisol, when overproduced, can contribute to weight factors and can also induce fatigue when levels are either too high or low.*
- DHEA– DHEA (Dehydroepiandrosterone) is another important hormone because it helps makes estrogen and testosterone.*

So, when experiencing increased feelings of stress and being overwhelmed, and healthy coping mechanisms aren't in place, the adrenals really start to feel it. Individuals may experience increased anxiety and discomfort as a result. As high levels of stress continue over time, it starts to really wear on the function of this gland. This process with the adrenals can be likened to a wet cloth. When you wring out a wet cloth, you're wringing it out and wringing it out, and eventually run out of water. Likewise, when the adrenal glands continue to be overworked, there's really not as much that the body can do when this gland can't give to the body anymore and will begin to significantly affect cortisol levels.

TESTING

As far as testing for adrenals specifically, saliva cortisol testing is the most accurate test as it is going to evaluate what's really going on throughout the course of a complete day. Typically, a saliva sample is collected in the morning, mid-day, late afternoon, and before bed to ensure the cortisol is starting at a high level in the morning and then slowly declining to a low throughout the day. If that's not happening, then the individual is most likely not feeling well and there are some very specific things needing to be addressed. In some instances, it is necessary to do a cortisol AM and blood test because insurance won't cover the saliva cortisol test. This method of testing gives some information and there is value in that. However, the saliva cortisol test is of the most benefit. Also, DHEA-S tests can be done via blood testing and can provide information in regards to good DHEA levels and DHEA helping the estrogen and testosterone to be more adequately produced in the body.

- Cortisol should be highest in the morning, so when getting out of bed, energy is good. As the day progresses, cortisol levels slowly decline so by night time it's low and should allow for the ability to fall asleep and stay asleep. This cycle, or the perfect rhythm, is called Circadian Rhythm of the Adrenal Function. However, both stress and age wear the adrenal gland down and so the cortisol is no longer able to be produced at the necessary levels in order to help with energy and proper sleep, and poor sleep will lead into a vicious cycle. Also, cortisol is a natural anti-inflammatory so some individuals with low cortisol levels can have more aches because the cortisol cannot put out little fires here and there. So, again, this can be a major factor for one's health if it's not being addressed.
- As mentioned previously, DHEA is extremely important because it makes estrogen and testosterone. In fact, 60% of hormone production, after the ovaries decline in their output, revolves around the adrenal glands' ability to make DHEA because the DHEA produces more estrogen and testosterone for the body to utilize. DHEA is important to check even in younger women who aren't even close to menopause, DHEA is an important tool for multiple reasons but especially to help ease the transition into menopause or to ease discomfort for those in the midst of menopause.

THYROID IMBALANCE

Adrenal and thyroid function go hand-in-hand, so if there is an adrenal issue, then there is a thyroid issue, and vice versa. Common thyroid symptoms, particularly for hypothyroid or low thyroid, would include irregular menstrual cycles, fatigue, inability to lose weight, hot flashes, cold intolerances, or temperature regulation issues can be wrapped around hypothyroidism. There is also the more rare occurrence of hyperthyroidism, which can cause heart racing and hot flashes, both of which are common to menopause. Testing would help to identify if there are issues with thyroid imbalance. Individuals should have annual testing done for at least TSH (which is a brain signal to the thyroid gland), Free T4, and Free T3. There are other tests that can be done to give us more information like Reverse T3 (although insurance sometimes doesn't cover that) as well as Anti-TPO and Antithyroglobulin Antibodies which both help in diagnosing Hashimoto's. Hashimoto's is an autoimmune disease where the immune system turns on itself and starts attacking its own thyroid, which over time causes a decline in thyroid function and can be why someone becomes hypothyroid. If this testing comes back positives for the Hashimoto's antibodies, further investigation is required to find out why the immune system is attacking the thyroid. This includes looking at other issues such as food allergies, gut function, and environmental factors that are contributing to the development of Hashimoto's. If these are issues, it is best to treat them using herbs if possible.

Herbal combinations that are helpful for the adrenals are formulas containing ashwagandha, Siberian ginseng, holy basil, and Rhodiola. Vitamin C is also an extremely important nutrient for the adrenal gland. If DHEA is low, then it needs to be replaced in the body while healing the adrenal glands. DHEA can be prescribed at doses anywhere between 5-50 mg. It is best to be able to do it at the lower end of 5 or 10mg to decrease any negative side effects that can occur like acne or hair loss, which could already be issues when someone going through menopause. Sometimes when the adrenals are really depleted or someone is physically depleted, IV therapy can be a great benefit as well, particularly high doses of Vitamin C just because the intestinal tract can't tolerate too much Vitamin C without causing loose stool, so having it given intravenously can really help speed up the process. Other actions that can be taken to be proactive in helping include stress management, seeing a therapist, talking with friends, regular exercise, promoting a good sleep routine, avoiding computers and other screen time before bed and sleeping in a dark room.

DIGESTIVE PROBLEMS

The next category of health issues that can masquerade as hormonal imbalance has to do with the digestive tract. Common digestive issues that can happen at any time in life but that might be seen more in menopausal women would be bloating, nauseousness, irritable bowel syndrome (IBS), constipation, frequent diarrhea, multiple bowel movements in a day or after meals, or heartburn. There are different underlying causes as to why these issues may be present. Difficulties such as weight gain or inability to lose weight can also be a result of digestive issues. Digestive issues can definitely slow metabolism, which contributes to weight gain or inability to lose weight. When digestive problems are the root cause of the weight challenges, hormone therapy is not going to fix it and other means are necessary to get the metabolism to click a little more and aid in the weight loss aspect. Digestive issues can also be connected to mood issues such as depression and/or anxiety and can also be connected to increased inflammation. Therefore, many of people who have arthritis or other inflammation-related conditions may see improvement by working to heal the digestive tract.

There are three areas to investigate when first addressing digestive issues:

- Candida*
- Small Intestinal Bacterial Overgrowth*
- Parasites*

Candida Albicans, typically referred to simply as Candida, is in everyone's intestinal tract along with bad bacteria and hopefully good bacteria. Problems occur when Candida levels become elevated, an imbalance of the gut flora occurs, and the body breaks down the candida and turns it into alcohol in the bloodstream. Candida can get too high through a variety of ways: use of oral birth control, extensive use of antibiotics which kills off the good bacteria, steroid use, and more importantly carbohydrates and sugar of any kind which stimulates the growth of Candida Albicans. These elevated candida levels can result in fatigue, inability to lose weight, arthritis, and mood issues.

Small Intestinal Bacterial Overgrowth, or SIBO, can happen for a few different reasons. Ultimately it boils down to bacteria being present in the small intestine, where it doesn't belong. The small intestine should be a sterile place where nutrients are absorbed to be utilized by the body. SIBO occurs when, instead of the small intestine remaining a sterile place, bacteria migrate from the large intestine into the small intestine, or the low acidity in the stomach does not break down the bacteria that travels through during digestion and it gets to the small intestine and stays there. As a result, the bacteria start eating the foods that you're eating and start releasing gases. These gases can affect us digestively. In fact, about 70% of IBS is related to SIBO. SIBO can interfere with the absorption of nutrients and hence the proper nutrients aren't getting to the body's cells for proper use. Some of the resulting symptoms include bloating, pressure on the top of the stomach, extensive belching, and fatigue. SIBO has also been connected to fibromyalgia which causes increased pain and tenderness in the body in addition to tiredness and can cause weight gain and hair loss.

Most people would probably never even consider the possibility of having parasites, especially if they have never traveled outside of the United States. However, even in the United States, the contraction of parasites is possible. Dogs and sushi both carry worms and parasites and again, if you are someone who travels outside the country, you could be exposed to parasites from other sources. Symptoms of parasites can include fatigue, weight gain, hot flashes, and night sweats. So, while some of these symptoms just may seem to be a normal part of the menopausal process, further investigation may reveal there's more to the story.

A stool test can confirm if someone has either Candida or parasites. A SIBO test is a breath test in which you are given a solution to drink. You then have to breathe into different tubes over a 2-hour time frame. If you are positive for SIBO, a gas called ethanol hydrogen will be present and collected in the tube. The laboratory will analyze the sample to see if those gases are present. Ultimately, if Candida, SIBO, or parasites are present, these underlying issues masquerading as menopausal symptoms will need to be addressed as they may not be connected to the hormonal imbalance whatsoever.

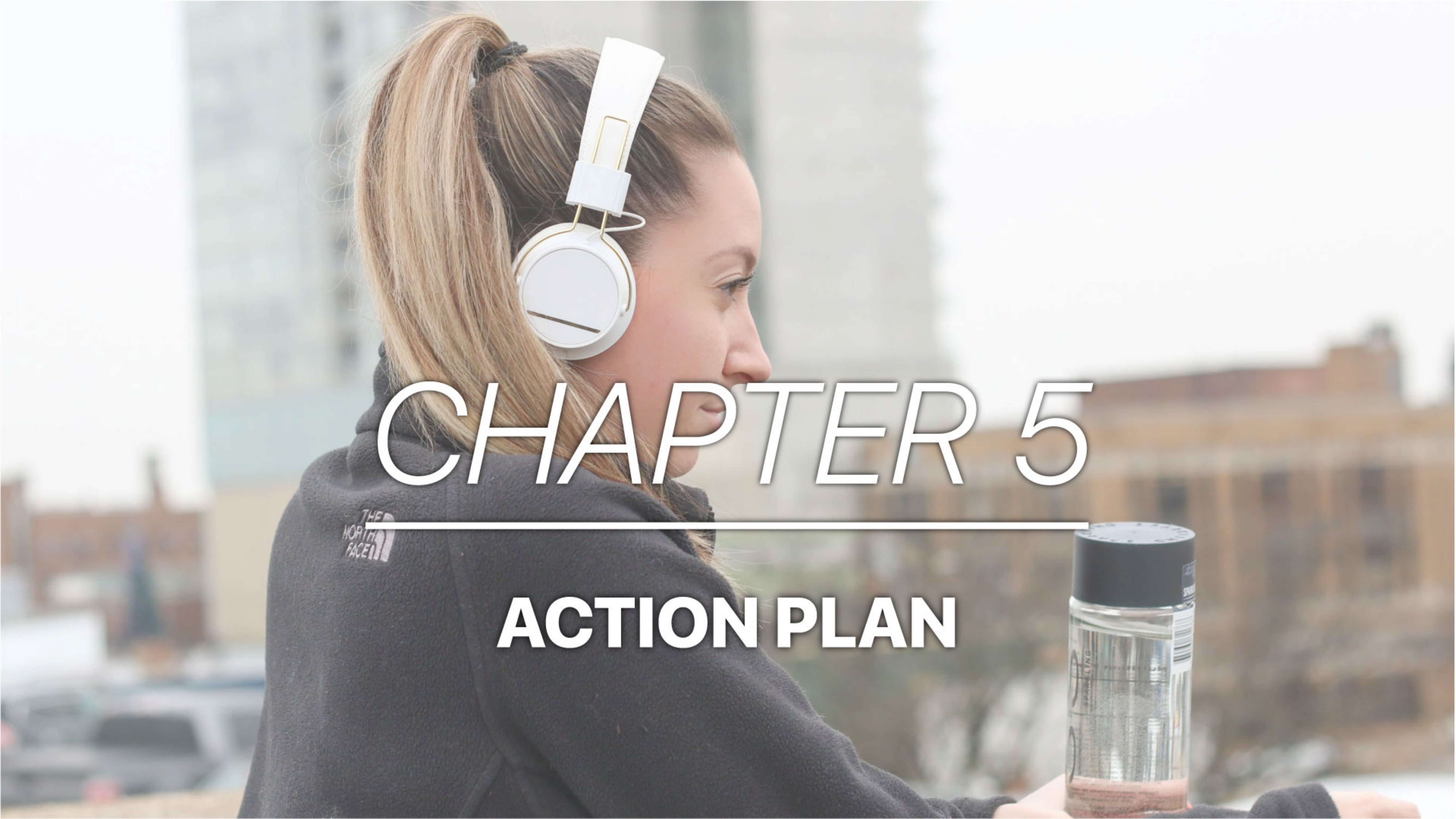
FOOD SENSITIVITIES

When there is a dysbiosis or an imbalance in the digestive tract, it will typically create inflammation in the intestinal lining, and therefore cause a propensity to have food sensitivities. Of course, when eating something your body doesn't like, you are going to feel even worse. Similar to the other health concerns already discussed, issues with food sensitivities and/or food allergies can lead to difficulty with weight loss and achy joints. The three most common food allergies are wheat, dairy, and baker's and brewer's yeast. Other common food allergies include eggs and nuts, like almonds or cashews.

Some people may be frustrated because while they are striving to eat healthily, they continue to gain weight. This can happen because while they're eating something that is, in theory, healthy, it may not be healthy for their body. Doing a food sensitivity test will be helpful in such instances as it provides a great deal of information as far as the individualization of the reaction of various foods specific to that person. This testing can look for 90 different food reactions, including Candida. Another way to assess for potential food sensitivities is simply eliminating the most common food sensitivities such as wheat, dairy, yeast, and sugar (as sugar creates inflammation and can stimulate Candida yeast in the gut).

When food sensitivities or allergies are identified, it is advised that the individual then avoid those foods and watch for improvements in symptoms. It is recommended that a person avoid the identified foods for at least eight weeks, as it does take time for the body to detox and find an established balance. If someone has many different food sensitivities, then their gut will be inflamed, and therefore may require harder work to get them in balance. Simultaneously treating for Candida during the food elimination process can be a great benefit. Probiotics and other gut healing herbs may also be necessary based on the severity of the food testing results.

Often times, some of the eliminated foods can slowly be added back into the diet to assess if it's no longer an issue or continues to trigger symptoms. If the food allergy or sensitivity remains, it ultimately becomes a choice as to whether you will continue to avoid the food or continue eating it and then deal with the associated consequences.



CHAPTER 5

ACTION PLAN



ACTION PLAN TO FEEL AMAZING

Action Plan Recap to Feel Amazing in Menopause:

- 1. Eat "YES!" Foods every day.*
- 2. Avoid "NO!" foods as much as possible.*
- 3. Consider your stress triggers and start a new habit to reduce stress.*
- 4. Practice good sleep hygiene.*
- 5. Try one of the top herbal remedies for menopause.*
- 6. Talk with a doctor about natural hormone replacement if you think that's right for you*
- 7. Get evaluated for hidden health issues.*

If you implement even one of the ideas discussed in this ebook, you'll be on your way to feeling more amazing in menopause!

Author's Note:

I work with women like you in my office every day. When I work with patients one-on-one, we're able to get more specific in identifying your health issues. When you come in for a visit with me, we explore your health history and choose lab tests that are most relevant to better understand your physiology and make individualized recommendations for nutrition, dietary supplements, and hormone replacement if needed. In order to explore your individual needs, I invite you to schedule an initial consultation with me today. Thank you for taking the time to read the information presented here. My passion is really helping women like you transition gracefully through the phases of life. Have a great day!

